

The Portrait of a Lady By Khushwant Singh

(2 February 1915-20 March 2014)

Khushwant Singh was one of the prominent Indian writers and columnists. In the story the author draws a pen portrait of his grandmother. He has beautifully written an account of his relationship with her grandmother.

Author Appearance of the grandmother
old, short, fat and slightly bent,
silver hair scattered untidily on wrinkled faces.

Dressed in white, hobbled around the house, one hand resting on waist the other telling the beads of a rosary not very pretty but always beautiful. compares her calm and serene face to a winter landscape.

A. Phases in Relationship

Phase I in Village 'Author's Early Childhood)

- grandmother woke up the author in the morning,
- plastered his wooden slate,
- served him stale chapatis with a little butter and sugar spread
- Accompanied him to school.
- He studied alphabets, she read the scriptures in the temple attached to the school.
- On their way back home she fed stale chapattis to stray dogs.

Phase 2 In City

- a turning point in their relationship.
- Author went to a city school in a motor bus
- the grandmother could no longer accompany him studied English, law of gravity, Archimedes' principle and many more things but no teaching of God and scriptures
- Grandmother was upset as she could not understand anything that was taught in school.
- She was distressed that there was no teaching of God and scriptures in the school.
- She disliked music as it was a monopoly of harlots and beggars.
- Grandmother felt secluded but didn't complain.

Phase 3 Author joins University

- given a separate room which snapped the common link of friendship.
- grandmother rarely talked to anyone, spent most of her time spinning wheel, reciting prayers, feeding the sparrows in the afternoon

Phase 4 Author goes abroad

- grandmother did not get disturbed, went to the railway station to see off the author and kept praying
- Author thought when the grandmother kissed him on the forehead

Phase 5 Author's Homecoming

author came back after five years, grandmother received a limited railway station celebrated the occasion by singing

songs of the homecoming of warriors on an old dilapidated drum, along with the Sadies of the neighbourhood.

B. Last hours of her life

Next morning, got a mild fever, knew that her end was near

- Didn't talk, wanted to spend the last moments of her life praying

- kept telling the beads of her rosary till her Hps stopped moving and the rosary fell from her lifeless fingers.

C. Mourning by the sparrows

- Hundreds of sparrows mourned her death as they sat silently, scattered around her body

- author's mother threw bread crumbs but sparrows took no notice, flew away quietly when Grandmother's body was carried away.

Q1. How did the grandmother spend her day in the village?

Ans. The grandmother spend her day by getting her grandson ready for the school, making breakfast for him and dropping him to school. Besides, she always remained busy in reciting prayers and telling the beads of her rosary.

Q.2. Why was the grandmother so disturbed when the narrator started going to the city school?

Ans. The grandmother was a religious lady who loved to read scriptures and tell the beads of the rosary. When her grandson told her about the subjects being taught at school, she felt offended and reacted strangely. According to her music was a monopoly of harlots and beggars.

Q.3. How did the sparrows express their sorrow when the author's grandmother died?

Ans. The author's grandmother was very fond of feeding sparrows with bread crumbs. When the grandmother died, the sparrows did not take notice of bread crumbs and flew away without eating them. In this way, they expressed their sorrow at her death.

Q.4. How did the author's grandmother behave just before her death?

Ans. The author's grandmother had got a fair enough idea about her upcoming death. Therefore, she decided not to waste even a single second while talking to her relatives but reciting the prayers and telling the beads of her rosary. She gave a clear signal to her family that she was no longer interested in talking to them.

Q.5. Why did the grandmother hate music?

Ans. Grandmother considered that music was indecent and was meant only for harlots and beggars. It was not meant for gentle folk or school children from respectable families.

Q.6. Why was it hard to believe that the author's grandmother was young and pretty?

Ans. It was hard to believe that the author's grandmother was young and pretty because the author, as a young boy, had always seen her as an old lady. She was of short stature and wrinkled all over. She had a quiet personality which everybody respected. So, to imagine her as a young and a pretty girl was a revolting thought for the author.

Q.7. Why was the grandmother dissatisfied with the city's education?

Ans. The grandmother was dissatisfied with the city's education because they never taught about the scriptures and God. The teachers taught science, the law of gravity etc. which was not of much importance to her.

Q.8. What was the turning point in the author's and the grandmother's relationship?

Ans. The author had to be sent to a big city for education. This was the turning point in his and the grandmother's relationship. The author began to receive education in an English medium school. The grandmother could not assist him with his assignment and therefore, became withdrawn. She began to feel lonely and fed sparrows in the afternoons.